The Bedtime Stall: 47 Excuses, One Thing That Worked

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For three weeks straight, bedtime ended the same way. Lights out at 8:00, and by 8:07 there were small bare feet padding down the hallway toward the living room.

“I’m thirsty.” “One more hug.” “There’s a monster in my closet.” “My toe itches.”

One night I counted. Nine trips. Nine separate appearances in the doorway, each delivered with total sincerity, like every single one was a genuine emergency. The water one was almost reasonable. The toe itch was not.

The monster got me the worst. Three nights in a row I went in with the flashlight, moved the jackets around, showed her the empty closet, did the whole performance. Night four, she looked me dead in the eye and said the monster had moved under the bed. I should have seen that coming a mile away.

Here’s what I tried first, and it flopped completely: the ticket system. I’d read about it somewhere — you give the kid three little cards, each one buys exactly one trip out of bed, and when they’re gone, they’re gone. Sounded brilliant. In practice, my daughter treated those tickets like a legal contract. She’d appear in the doorway holding one up like a tiny lawyer presenting evidence. “This one is for water. The hug didn’t count because you didn’t say it counts.” By 8:20 she’d negotiated herself two extra trips and I was standing there getting out-argued by a three-year-old. We abandoned the tickets after four days.

What actually worked was boring. Two boring things.

First: silent returns. No talking, no eye contact, no negotiations, no water refills. She comes out, I take her hand, walk her back to bed, pull the blanket up, and leave. That’s it. The first night I did it eleven times. Eleven. I wanted to scream into a pillow between trips. Night two: six times. Night

three: four. By night five, twice. Turns out the trips were the entertainment and I was the show — every “go back to bed, sweetie” was a little bedtime encore. Take away the audience and the show closes.

Second, and honestly this was the bigger fix: we moved bedtime twenty minutes earlier. 8:00 became 7:40. I know it sounds backwards — she’s stalling, so put her to bed earlier? But she wasn’t stalling because she wasn’t tired. She was stalling because she was overtired, and an overtired three-year-old’s brain goes completely feral. The 8:00 bedtime was aspirational parenting; 7:40 was honest parenting. Once she was genuinely sleepy at lights-out, the excuses just dried up.

Last night she came out once. Once! For water. I gave her the water — I’m not a monster — and she walked back to bed on her own. I stood in the hallway holding an empty cup feeling like I’d won the lottery.